

D268

Introduction to Communication: Connecting with Others

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

During a video call, a project manager explains a deadline change. As she speaks, she sees a teammate frown and immediately adds an example to clarify. The call used the company's new meeting platform and ran eight minutes over. Which model of communication does this best illustrate?

- A. The linear model.
- B. The interactive model.
- C. A mass-communication model, because it ran on a digital platform.
- D. The transactional model.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A new analyst from another region reads an email saying a report is due EOD and assumes it means end of the week. The email was sent from the CFO's phone at 6:40 a.m. with the subject line in bold. What type of noise interfered with the message?

- A. Psychological noise, because the analyst is new and may be anxious.
- B. Physical noise.
- C. Semantic noise.
- D. Physiological noise, because it was sent so early in the morning.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which example is psychological noise?

- A. A speaker uses acronyms the audience does not know.
- B. A listener is so worried about rumored layoffs that she misses the key points of a meeting.
- C. A leaf blower runs outside the meeting-room window.
- D. A listener has a pounding headache.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A supervisor tells a team member, "Great job on the presentation," while sighing, looking at his phone, and avoiding eye contact. The presentation had 22 slides and ended on time. How is the team member most likely to interpret the message?

- A. She will doubt the praise and trust the negative nonverbal cues.
- B. She will decide the message had no meaning, since mixed messages never communicate anything.
- C. She will rely on the words alone, since he said nothing negative.
- D. She will assume the praise was about keeping to the slide count.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

An employee tells an HR generalist, "I keep getting pulled into other teams' projects, and my own work slips." The meeting room has a whiteboard, and the generalist has a laptop open to the employee's file. Which response best shows active listening?

- A. "Hold on, let me pull up your file on my laptop first."
- B. "You should always say no to other teams."
- C. "Everyone feels stretched right now; you'll get used to it."
- D. "So other teams keep pulling you in, and it's making it hard to finish your own work. Is that right?"

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A U.S.-based vendor emails a partner firm in Japan, often described as a high-context culture: "We need a firm yes or no by Friday." The partner replies, "We will consider it carefully," and the deal stalls. The two firms have worked together for five years and use the same project-tracking software. What best explains the misunderstanding?

- A. The low-context sender expected an explicit answer, while the high-context reply signaled hesitation through polite, indirect wording.
- B. Translation errors always cause cross-cultural problems like this.
- C. The Japanese partner is low-context and simply needs more detail.
- D. The shared software failed to deliver the message on time.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A manager from a low-context culture will present a proposal to colleagues from a high-context culture. Which adjustment fits best?

- A.** Allow time for relationship-building and pay attention to what is implied, not only what is said.
- B.** Never make any direct statement at all.
- C.** Be even more blunt and communicate only in writing.
- D.** Speak louder and more slowly throughout.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A manager must tell a long-time employee that her position is being eliminated. The manager's calendar is booked in 15-minute blocks, and the company recently rolled out a new chat tool. Which channel is most appropriate?

- A.** A detailed email she can read on her own time.
- B.** A department-wide announcement so everyone hears at once.
- C.** A private face-to-face meeting (or live video if remote).
- D.** A message in the new chat tool so it fits her schedule.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

In a weekly status meeting run by a visiting director, a teammate interrupts a coordinator three times while she presents budget figures. The meeting is being recorded for the regional office. Which response is assertive?

- A.** Staying quiet, then complaining about the teammate to others afterward.
- B.** Saying nothing because the meeting is being recorded.
- C.** "I'd like to finish my update, and then I'll take your questions."
- D.** "You always interrupt me, and it's rude."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which statement is aggressive rather than assertive?

- A.** “Sure, I’ll just do everyone’s work again.”
- B.** “You never listen, so I’m done explaining this.”
- C.** “Whatever works for you is fine.”
- D.** “I feel frustrated when deadlines move without notice; can we agree on a heads-up?”

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

Two department leads disagree about how to split a shared budget. They spend a long session uncovering both teams’ underlying needs and design a plan that fully meets both. They met in the executive boardroom over lunch. Which conflict style did they use?

- A.** Avoiding, because they met informally over lunch.
- B.** Collaborating.
- C.** Compromising.
- D.** Accommodating.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

To reach a quick agreement, each side gives up part of what it wanted and accepts a middle split. Which conflict style is this?

- A.** Accommodating, because giving something up is yielding.
- B.** Competing.
- C.** Collaborating.
- D.** Compromising.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

During a video call, a project manager explains a deadline change. As she speaks, she sees a teammate frown and immediately adds an example to clarify. ~~The call used the company's new meeting platform and ran eight minutes over.~~ Which model of communication does this best illustrate?

Target word: name the model **Decides:** She adjusted while speaking in response to live feedback.

A	Confusion set	Linear is one-way with no feedback.
B	Adjacent category	Interactive includes feedback but in turns, not at the same moment.
C	Camouflage	The platform does not decide the model; the live feedback does.
D	Correct	Both people sent and received at once, and feedback shaped the message in real time.

2. Answer C Concept 2

A new analyst from another region reads an email saying a report is due EOD and assumes it means end of the week. ~~The email was sent from the CFO's phone at 6:40 a.m. with the subject line in bold.~~ What type of noise interfered with the message?

Target word: classify the noise **Decides:** An abbreviation was misunderstood.

A	Adjacent category	Nothing in the stem shows worry or bias; the problem is the term.
B	Confusion set	Physical noise is outside interference like sound or a bad connection.
C	Correct	Confusion over the meaning of a term (EOD) is semantic.
D	Camouflage	The send time does not decide what went wrong.

3. Answer B Concept 2 · transfer

Which example is psychological noise?

Target word: find the psychological example — reverse of classifying one case **Decides:** Internal worry blocks attention.

A	Confusion set	Unknown terms are semantic noise.
B	Correct	Mental or emotional distraction is psychological noise.
C	Confusion set	Outside sound is physical noise.
D	Adjacent category	A bodily condition is physiological, not psychological.

4. Answer A Concept 3

A supervisor tells a team member, "Great job on the presentation," while sighing, looking at his phone, and avoiding eye contact. ~~The presentation had 22 slides and ended on time.~~ How is the team member most likely to interpret the message?

Target word: likely interpretation **Decides:** The nonverbal cues contradict the words.

A	Correct	When channels conflict, people tend to believe the nonverbal.
B	Absolute language	Mixed messages do communicate; the nonverbal part usually wins.
C	Dropped element	Leaves out the nonverbal channel entirely.
D	Camouflage	The slide count does not decide how she reads his tone.

5. Answer D Concept 4

An employee tells an HR generalist, "I keep getting pulled into other teams' projects, and my own work slips." ~~The meeting room has a whiteboard, and the generalist has a laptop open to the employee's file.~~ Which response best shows active listening?

Target word: active listening response **Decides:** Paraphrase and check understanding.

A	Camouflage	Turns attention to the file instead of the speaker.
B	Absolute language	Jumps to sweeping advice before understanding.
C	Adjacent category	Reassurance that dismisses the concern is not listening.
D	Correct	Paraphrases the meaning and checks for accuracy.

6. Answer A Concept 5

A U.S.-based vendor emails a partner firm in Japan, often described as a high-context culture: "We need a firm yes or no by Friday." The partner replies, "We will consider it carefully," and the deal stalls. ~~The two firms have worked together for five years and use the same project tracking software.~~ What best explains the misunderstanding?

Target word: cause of the misunderstanding **Decides:** Explicit request met by an indirect, high-context reply.

A	Correct	Different context styles read the same words differently.
B	Absolute language	Nothing shows a translation error; the gap is in style.
C	Inverted operation	Reverses the styles; the indirect reply is the high-context signal.
D	Camouflage	The message arrived; the tool does not decide the issue.

7. Answer A Concept 5 • transfer

A manager from a low-context culture will present a proposal to colleagues from a high-context culture. Which adjustment fits best?

Target word: adjust toward high-context audience **Decides:** Relationship and implied meaning matter to the audience.

A	Correct	High-context audiences rely on relationship and context.
B	Absolute language	Adapting does not mean dropping all clarity.
C	Inverted operation	Pushes further toward low-context style.
D	Adjacent category	Addresses language pace, not context style.

8. Answer C Concept 6

A manager must tell a long-time employee that her position is being eliminated. ~~The manager's calendar is booked in 15-minute blocks, and the company recently rolled out a new chat tool.~~ Which channel is most appropriate?

Target word: channel for bad news **Decides:** Sensitive, emotional news needs a rich channel.

A	Adjacent category	Email suits routine facts, not emotional news.
B	Dropped element	Drops the privacy the person is owed.
C	Correct	A rich channel allows tone, empathy, and questions.
D	Camouflage	Tool and calendar details do not decide the right channel.

9. Answer C Concept 7

In a weekly status meeting ~~run by a visiting director~~, a teammate interrupts a coordinator three times while she presents budget figures. ~~The meeting is being recorded for the regional office.~~ Which response is assertive?

Target word: assertive reply **Decides:** Clear, respectful statement of her need.

A	Confusion set	Passive-aggressive, not assertive.
B	Camouflage	The recording does not decide how to respond.
C	Correct	States her need directly and respectfully.
D	Adjacent category	Attacks the person with a generalization; that is aggressive.

10. Answer B Concept 7 · transfer

Which statement is aggressive rather than assertive?

Target word: spot aggressive — reverse of picking the assertive one **Decides:** Blames and attacks the other person.

A	Adjacent category	Sarcasm is passive-aggressive rather than openly aggressive.
B	Correct	Blaming, absolute “you” language is aggressive.
C	Confusion set	Passive: gives up one’s own needs.
D	Inverted operation	That is the assertive model, the opposite of what is asked.

11. Answer B Concept 8

Two department leads disagree about how to split a shared budget. They spend a long session uncovering both teams’ underlying needs and design a plan that fully meets both. ~~They met in the executive boardroom over lunch.~~ Which conflict style did they use?

Target word: name the style **Decides:** Both sides’ needs were fully met.

A	Camouflage	The setting does not decide the style.
B	Correct	High concern for both sides produced a plan that met both fully.
C	Confusion set	Compromise means each side gives something up.
D	Adjacent category	Accommodating means one side yields to the other.

12. Answer D Concept 8 · transfer

To reach a quick agreement, each side gives up part of what it wanted and accepts a middle split. Which conflict style is this?

Target word: name the style from the outcome **Decides:** Both sides gave something up.

A	Dropped element	Drops that both sides gave; accommodating is one side yielding.
B	Adjacent category	Competing pushes one side’s goal over the other.
C	Confusion set	Collaborating seeks a solution that meets both sides fully.
D	Correct	Each side trades away part of its goal.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	3	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	8	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Transactional model	In live communication both people send and receive at the same time, and feedback shapes the message as it happens.	Picturing communication as one-way (linear) or strict turn-taking.	A speaker adjusting mid-sentence to a listener's reaction.
2	Types of noise	Physical noise is outside interference; physiological is bodily; psychological is mental or emotional; semantic is confusion over word meaning.	Calling every misunderstanding physical noise, or mixing up semantic and psychological.	Jargon or a misread term (semantic) vs. worry or bias (psychological).
3	Nonverbal carries the weight	When words and nonverbal cues conflict, people tend to believe the nonverbal cues.	Assuming the literal words decide what the listener takes away.	Positive words paired with a sigh, eye roll, or turned-away posture.
4	Active listening	Active listening means attending, paraphrasing the speaker's meaning, and checking understanding before advising.	Jumping to advice, reassurance, or your own story.	"Which response shows active listening?"
5	High- vs. low-context cultures	Low-context communicators rely on explicit words; high-context communicators rely on relationship, setting, and implied meaning.	Reading a polite, indirect reply as a yes, or reversing which style is which.	A direct request met with a vague or polite deferral across cultures.
6	Channel richness	Sensitive, complex, or emotional messages need rich channels (face-to-face, live video); routine facts can go through lean channels (email, chat).	Choosing the fastest or newest channel for bad news.	Delivering difficult news or resolving a complex issue.
7	Assertive vs. aggressive vs. passive	Assertive communication states your needs clearly and respectfully, often with "I" statements; aggressive attacks the other person; passive avoids saying what you need.	Thinking assertive means forceful, or that staying quiet is polite and effective.	Which reply to an interruption or unfair request is assertive.
8	Conflict management styles	Collaborating meets both parties' full needs; compromising splits the difference; accommodating yields; competing pushes one side; avoiding sidesteps.	Calling any agreement a compromise.	Whether both sides got everything, gave something up, or one side yielded.

Course scope (public description): Welcome to Introduction to Communication: Connecting with Others! It may seem like common knowledge that communication skills are important, and that communicating with others is inescapable in our everyday lives. While this may appear simplistic, the study of communication is actually complex, dynamic, and multifaceted. Strong communication skills are invaluable to strengthening a multitude of aspects of life. Specifically, this course will focus on communication in the professional setting, and present material from multiple vantage points, including communicating with others in a variety of contexts, across situations, and with diverse populations. Upon completion, you will have a deeper understanding of both your own

and others' communication behaviors, and a toolbox of effective behaviors to enhance your experience in the workplace.